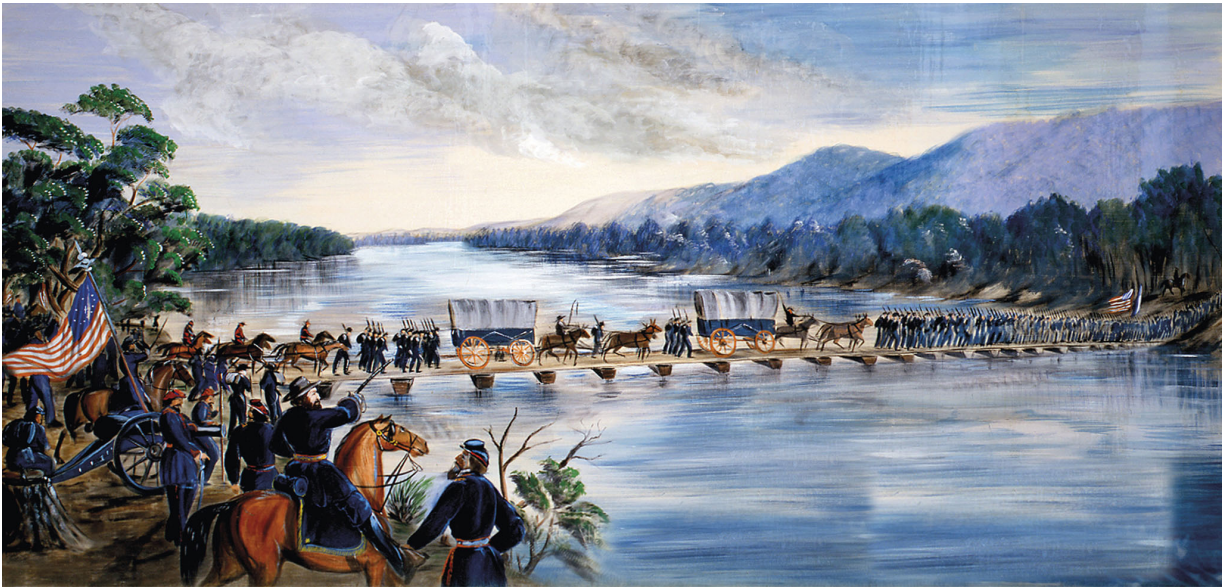


existed because of the fall of Chattanooga to the Union. It would take nine days for these reinforcements—12,000 strong—to reach Bragg from the East, but they would arrive just in time.

In early September, Bragg made a series of attempts to bait Rosecrans into advancing his army corps. On three occasions the Union commander took the bait, and could have been badly mauled. But in each instance one or other of Bragg's subordinates failed to follow his orders sufficiently. Rosecrans grew cautious, consolidating his army along the West Chickamauga Creek. Bragg was determined to flank him and to get between him and his base at Chattanooga. On September 18, the first of Longstreet's troops arrived, and after a day of desultory skirmishing, Bragg decided to wait to the morrow to hit the Union army in full force.



Crossing the Tennessee

Rosecrans's troops cross the Tennessee River west of Chattanooga, in early September 1863, as depicted in William Travis's epic panorama on the exploits of the Army of the Cumberland.

The Battle of Chickamauga

As the sun rose on September 19, the pickets of each side, after lying close to each other the night before, opened fire with a sharp exchange. The fire grew in intensity, especially on the Union left, where, despite the thick woods, Bragg attempted to outflank General George Thomas's corps. Brigade after brigade was sent in by